They're always watching. Always.

your passwords regularly are not talking through their hats. You may not realise the importance of multiple passwords till your account is hacked. While your password itself may be secure, it's how the website that you're logging into handles the password that is suspect. Take the recent hacking of Adobe's database; the site was probably one that you trusted with your credentials and maybe you were a bit lax and you used the same password that you use to login to, say, facebook. All the hacker has to do is find your identity online (using your profile information on Adobe's site) and just try your Adobe password on every social network and forum that you're on! We're not saying that Adobe is particularly lax, what we're saying is that if Adobe can be hacked, what about the more risqué forums that you might be frequenting?

- **Two-step authentication:** An essential supplement to your password. If you have this option, enable it. This is easily one of the safest and most secure methods of logging in anywhere. It might be more cumbersome, but trust us when we say this, you'll be thanking your lucky stars the day you discover that your accounts have been compromised.
- **A double-life:** If you're really paranoid about your online life, lead a double life. Create an entirely new online persona, complete with fake address and birthday. Hell, create multiple personas. Use those details as credentials for sites that you would not want linked to your real life.
- **Public Wi-Fi:** Try not to use public Wi-Fi networks to access private and secure data that you would not have fall into the wrong hands. If you really must use a public network, use a VPN (more on that later), but even that might not be enough.
- **Encryption:** Don't leave sensitive data just lying around. Leaving passwords in Google docs or Skydrive is not the intelligent thing to do. If you really must offload private data, use utilities such as true-crypt to encrypt your info before you upload the data. But remember, the best place to store any data is your memory.
- **Google yourself:** We're pretty sure that some of you do this anyway, but for those who don't, this is not really vanity. If one wants to remain anonymous, one must pride oneself on one's inability to find oneself.
- **Misc. tips:** There's not much else really. Just make sure you understand how privacy works on various sites, don't put any compromising information online and be careful with your passwords.
- **Incognito:** It's best if you browse the web in incognito mode wherever possible. Most importantly, don't sign in unless you really have to. Even for that Google search. Also, enable "Do Not Track" in your browser. Almost every modern browser from Internet Explorer onwards has this feature. This will at least prevent your data from being logged by sites that comply with the request. Bear in mind that many sites do not comply with a "Do Not Track" request so it's not a complete solution.

It's imperative that you understand one thing though, the incognito mode doesn't make you invisible. All that the mode really does is delete browsing and tracking data on the PC that you're working on. All your actual history has already been mapped and tracked by your ISP and any other organization taking an interest in what you're doing.

Just because you're wearing a mask doesn't mean you're invisible

- **Anti-social behavior:** If you truly value for privacy, stay away from social networks. Facebook for example, with its myriad privacy faux pas is just one of the biggest sources of information on your entire online (and real) life.

Now that we've got the basics out of the way, it's time to move on to the more advanced stuff. If you've implemented the above steps, your online life should already be pretty secure, but, to go that extra mile, here are a set of steps that more advanced (or paranoid) users can try out.

## VPN

One of the easiest ways to get tracked online is via your ISP. Anything you do online can, and probably will be

linked back to your IP address, a digital signature of sorts. One way you can get around this is by using a Virtual Private Network (VPN). How it works is very simple. You access the VPN via your ISP, so the ISP knows you went that far, but after that, all your Internet traffic is routed via that VPN provider's servers. Basically, no matter what you're doing or what site you're browsing, all your ISP knows is that you've accessed that VPN and no other site. As you can see from the box labelled "How does the Internet work?", the Internet is nothing more than a collection of interconnected PCs and routers. Each of those PCs (servers in this case) will keep logs of your IP